■ THE DAILY GOODS STORY SCOUT - Thursday, September 10, 2026

TODAY'S RUNDOWN SLOTS

THE LIST (5 stories)

■ *Another big James Talarico interview is punted to YouTube due to FCC threats■ / Jimmy Kimmel is the latest talk show host to move an interview with Talarico online after the FCC "threatened" him.*

The Angle: *This is the same late-night-vs-FCC fight that's been simmering all year, and now it's happening again in real time with a sitting late-night host — that's a live free-speech-on-TV debate, not just industry gossip.*

- **Jimmy Kimmel** pulled his interview with Texas state rep **James Talarico** off broadcast and dropped it on **YouTube** instead.
- Kimmel says he made the move after the **FCC** "threatened" him over the segment.
- It's reportedly not the first time a Talarico interview got bumped from TV to online-only under similar pressure.

The Debate Starter

- Should a federal regulator have this much sway over who gets booked on late-night TV?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 25 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.theverge.com/policy/993383/jimmy-kimmel-fcc-brendan-carr-james-talarico

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■ *Mexico reintroduced bison in 2025 after more than 100 years: Just months later, the ecosystem is restoring itself*

The Angle: *A century-old absence, undone in months: Mexico reintroduced wild bison in 2025 and the surrounding ecosystem is already bouncing back, a rare good-news environmental story with real 'nature heals fast' payoff.*

- **Mexico** reintroduced **bison** to the wild in **2025** for the first time in over **100 years**
- Just months after reintroduction, the surrounding ecosystem is reportedly already showing signs of restoration

The Feel-Good Angle

- Nature bounced back faster than anyone expected — proof that some environmental damage isn't as permanent as we think.

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://en.as.com/latest_news/mexico-reintroduced-bisons-in-2025-after-more-than-100-years-just-months-later-the-ecosystem-is-restoring-itself-f202609-n/

■ *Massie introduces bill to restrict federal funding for Flock cameras*

The Angle: *Flock Safety's AI license plate cameras have quietly popped up in thousands of communities nationwide, and now a sitting congressman is pushing back on Capitol Hill - this is the surveillance-vs-safety fight that cuts across party lines.*

- **Rep. Thomas Massie** (R-KY) introduced a bill targeting federal funding for **Flock Safety** camera systems.
- **Flock** cameras are AI-powered license plate readers used by police departments across the country.
- The move taps into a growing bipartisan debate over mass surveillance and how license plate data gets stored and shared.

- Massie has built a reputation as one of Congress's most vocal privacy hawks, often breaking from his own party on these issues.

The Debate Starter

- Do those license plate cameras make your neighborhood safer, or is this just surveillance creep - call in and tell us where you land.

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.courier-journal.com/story/news/politics/2026/09/03/thomas-massie-introduces-bill-to-limit-federal-funding-of-flock-cameras/91592916007/

■ *Iceland to propose whaling ban, leaving Norway and Japan isolated.*

The Angle: *Iceland moving to ban whaling would leave only Norway and Japan still hunting whales commercially — a real shift in a decades-long global fight environmentalists have been pushing for.*

- **Iceland** is set to propose a formal ban on whaling in its own waters.
- If it passes, **Norway** and **Japan** would be left as the last major nations still commercially whaling.
- The move marks a symbolic turning point in the long-running international fight over commercial whale hunting.

The Debate Starter

- Should the last holdout countries be pressured to follow Iceland's lead and end whaling for good?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.nbcnews.com/world/europe/iceland-propose-whaling-ban-leaving-norway-japan-isolated-rcna596976

■ *After $300 million in tariff refunds, Nintendo won't give players cash back but you will get "30% off" in a "Customer Appreciation Sale"*

The Angle: *Tariff refunds are supposed to trickle down, but Nintendo's version is a store discount dressed up as a 'thank you' - it's the kind of corporate spin that gets people fired up about who actually benefits from tariff relief.*

- Nintendo reportedly received **$300 million** in tariff refunds
- Instead of passing savings directly to customers, they're running a **'Customer Appreciation Sale'**
- The deal: **30% off**, not cash back

The Debate Starter

- Is a '30% off sale' a real refund, or just marketing spin dressed up as generosity?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.gamesradar.com/games/after-usd300-million-in-tariff-refunds-nintendo-wont-give-players-cash-back-but-you-will-get-30-percent-off-in-a-customer-appreciation-sale/

Backup options:

■ *Florida woman sues over wrongful arrest tied to Flock camera data*

The Angle: *Flock Safety's license-plate cameras are popping up in neighborhoods all over the U.S. and Canada, and this lawsuit taps straight into the growing unease about AI surveillance making real-world mistakes with real consequences.*

- A **Florida woman** is suing after she says she was wrongfully arrested based on data from a **Flock Safety** license-plate camera.
- **Flock Safety**'s automated camera network is used by police departments across the U.S. and Canada to track vehicles by plate number.
- The case puts a spotlight on how much police lean on AI-driven surveillance tech without double-checking it against real evidence.

The Debate Starter

- Would you trust a camera's read on a license plate enough to put someone in handcuffs?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.foxnews.com/tech/innocent-woman-says-police-use-flock-camera-led-13-days-jail?msockid=302df82831bf6695193aed763014675d

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CANADIAN NEWS (3 stories)

■ *Ontario Science Centre laying off entire science department*

The Angle: *The Ontario Science Centre has been stuck in limbo since its abrupt 2024 closure over structural safety issues, and now word is the actual science staff are getting laid off entirely - which raises the obvious, kind of absurd question of what's even left to call a "science centre."*

- The layoffs reportedly wipe out the **entire science department** at the **Ontario Science Centre**.
- The centre has been dogged by controversy since its sudden **2024 closure**, with its future location and mandate still unresolved.

The Irony Alert

- A science centre laying off all its scientists - so what exactly are taxpayers left funding?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.ctvnews.ca/toronto/politics/queens-park/article/ontario-science-centre-laying-off-entire-science-department/

■ *Canada and Ukraine sign 100-year agreement to work together on defence, energy and trade*

The Angle: *A full century-long pact covering defence, energy and trade is a huge, unusual commitment - it signals how deep Canada's ties to Ukraine now run, and it's the kind of long-horizon deal that raises the obvious question: what happens over the NEXT 100 years to make this worth it?*

- **Canada** and **Ukraine** signed an agreement spanning **100 years**
- The deal covers cooperation on **defence, energy, and trade**

The Debate Starter

- A 100-year commitment to another country - smart long-term alliance-building, or a promise no government can actually guarantee?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.theglobeandmail.com/business/article-canada-and-ukraine-sign-100-year-agreement-trade-defence/

■■ *Canada’s Most Popular Conservative Is Mark Carney*

The Angle: *A viral Reddit thread claims Liberal PM Mark Carney is more popular with conservative-leaning Canadians than any actual Conservative politician - a head-scratcher that gets at just how scrambled party loyalty has become north of the border.*

- The claim comes from a thread on **r/canada**, not a formal poll release
- **Mark Carney** currently sits as Canada's **Liberal** Prime Minister
- The irony: a Liberal leader reportedly outpolling the **Conservative Party** with conservative voters themselves

The Debate Starter

- If your favorite politician is a Liberal PM, can you really call yourself a conservative anymore?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://thewalrus.ca/canadas-most-popular-conservative-is-mark-carney/

Backup options:

■■ *Zelenskyy says Canada has agreed a big air defence package for Ukraine*

The Angle: *Zelenskyy just publicly namechecked Canada for a major air defence deal at a moment when Russian strikes on Ukrainian cities are ramping up — it's a reminder Canada's more involved in this war than most Canadians probably realize.*

- **Volodymyr Zelenskyy** says Canada has agreed to a significant air defence package for Ukraine
- Details on cost, equipment type, and timeline aren't yet confirmed in early reporting

The Debate Starter

- Should Canada be spending more on Ukraine's air defence, or is it time to pull back and focus at home?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cp24.com/news/canada/2026/09/10/pm-carney-tells-zelenskyy-canada-will-help-ukraine-rebuild/

■ *Poilievre tells U.S. TV Canadians are 'wounded' and 'confused' to be in America's crosshairs*

The Angle: *Canada's opposition leader took his case straight to an American audience, calling out how blindsided and hurt Canadians feel being treated as a target south of the border - a soundbite that taps right into the ongoing cross-border tension both hosts' audiences are already living through.*

- **Pierre Poilievre** took his message directly to a **U.S. TV audience** instead of just Canadian outlets.
- He said Canadians feel **'wounded'** and **'confused'** about ending up in **America's crosshairs**.
- The comments frame Canada as blindsided by how it's being treated by its closest ally.

The Debate Starter

- Do you feel 'wounded and confused' by how the U.S. has been treating Canada lately, or is that overselling it?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/poilievre-new-york-carney-trump-9.7338906

■ *Man accused in Mexican condo scheme claims he was a victim, too*

The Angle: *Man accused in Mexican condo scheme claims he was a victim, too*

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/world/mexico-fraud-play-del-carmen-9.7338103?cmp=rss

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ENTERTAINMENT (4 stories)

■ *Netflix special proves Stavros Halkias is the Left's best spokesperson*

The Angle: *A think-piece is making the rounds arguing that comedian Stavros Halkias' new Netflix special does more to sell progressive politics than most actual politicians - which is exactly the kind of 'wait, really?' claim that gets people talking.*

The Debate Starter

- Do comedians actually change minds on politics, or just preach to the choir that already agrees with them?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.sfgate.com/sf-culture/article/netflix-comedy-stavros-halkias-22423004.php

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■ *Andrew Garfield Immediately Stopped Using ChatGPT After 'Artificial' Shoot: 'The More You Know'*

The Angle: *It's the classic AI-in-Hollywood freakout story with a celebrity face on it — a movie star reportedly got spooked enough by using ChatGPT on set that he quit cold turkey, which taps right into the bigger 'is AI coming for art' conversation everyone's already having.*

- **Andrew Garfield** reportedly stopped using **ChatGPT** after working on the film **'Artificial'**
- His reaction was summed up with the line: **'The more you know'**

The Debate Starter

- Would learning how AI actually works behind the scenes make you use it less — or more?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.thewrap.com/culture-lifestyle/culture/andrew-garfield-chatgpt-artificial-sam-altman-movie-kimmel/

■■ *Dan Schneider Loses 'Quiet on Set' Defamation Suit on Appeal*

The Angle: *The former Nickelodeon boss tried to fight back against the bombshell documentary that reignited scrutiny of his shows, and the courts just shut him down again — a real gut-check moment for anyone who watched 'Quiet on Set.'*

- **Dan Schneider** filed a **defamation suit** over the docuseries **'Quiet on Set'**
- An **appeals court** has now ruled against him, upholding the earlier dismissal
- The case centered on how the documentary characterized his behavior on-set at **Nickelodeon**

The Debate Starter

- Does this ruling feel like accountability finally sticking, or are we still not getting the full story?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/tv/news/dan-schneider-quiet-on-set-defamation-dismissed-appeal-1236858005/

■ *Hasan Piker's reaction to his photo being featured in an ad shown at the Republican midterm convention.*

The Angle: *A left-wing streamer becoming a literal ad villain at a Republican convention is pure politics-meets-internet-culture chaos, and his reaction is already ricocheting through gossip and political corners of the internet alike.*

- **Hasan Piker**, one of the biggest political streamers on **Twitch**, reportedly turned up as imagery in an ad shown at the **Republican midterm convention**.
- His response to being used that way is what's now circulating and fueling the story.
- The story is blowing up on **Reddit's r/fauxmoi**, a sub that usually tracks celebrity gossip, not political messaging.

The Debate Starter

- Fair game or foul play: should political parties get to slap a streamer's face on attack ads without them saying yes?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://v.redd.it/u7awxtds9moh1

Backup options:

■ *Hasbro condemns the Department of Homeland Security for using Optimus Prime in a post.*

The Angle: *A federal agency borrowing a beloved 80s cartoon icon for its own messaging, only to get publicly called out by the toy company that owns him — it's the kind of brand-versus-government mismatch that writes its own punchline.*

- **Hasbro**, which owns the **Transformers** franchise, publicly condemned the **Department of Homeland Security** for using **Optimus Prime** in one of its posts.
- The clash pits a childhood-nostalgia mascot against a federal agency's messaging, which is exactly the kind of mismatch that gets people talking online.
- Story is circulating out of **r/fauxmoi**, suggesting it's already generating chatter in pop-culture circles.

The Debate Starter

- Should brands have a say when the government uses their characters to push a message?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.reddit.com/gallery/1wcohtg

■ *Elon Musk calls documentary about him a 'hit piece' after buzzy debut*

The Angle: *A splashy new documentary about Elon Musk just premiered to buzz, and now Musk is reportedly lawyering up and torching the director online — a billionaire-vs-filmmaker feud is exactly the kind of messy, quotable drama that writes its own segment.*

- **Elon Musk** is reportedly taking legal action over a new documentary about him
- The film debuted this week to a lot of buzz
- Musk called it a **'hit piece'** on social media
- He went after director **Alex Gibney** directly, calling him a **'horrible human'**

The Debate Starter

- Is this Musk protecting his image, or proof the documentary hit a nerve?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/entertainment/musk-documentary-reaction-9.7339185?cmp=rss

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■ *Fans ‘Burnin’ Up’ over NFL’s odd Jonas Brothers halftime choice*

The Angle: *The NFL took its Melbourne game global with a Jonas Brothers halftime show on Netflix, and fans are split on whether a boy-band reunion belongs at midfield during an actual game.*

- The **Jonas Brothers** played a **five-song halftime set** during **Rams vs. 49ers** in **Melbourne**.
- The game aired as a **live Netflix broadcast**, part of the NFL's push into streaming and international markets.
- Fans flooded social media with reactions to the pick, split between excitement and confusion over the choice.

The Debate Starter

- Good halftime pick or proof the NFL will book literally anyone for a streaming game?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/10/sports/fans-react-odd-jonas-brothers-halftime-show-rams-49ers-game/

■ *Fans bash Netflix for sound issues during the Rams and 49ers game: ‘It’s almost unwatchable’*

The Angle: *Netflix paid big to stream NFL games and fans are torching them online for busted audio during the Rams-49ers matchup — a real gut-check for their live sports push.*

- Fans flooded social media calling the broadcast **"almost unwatchable"** due to sound issues.
- The audio wasn't the only complaint — viewers also took aim at other parts of the broadcast.
- Comes as **Netflix** continues expanding into live NFL streaming.

The Debate Starter

- Should Netflix stick to movies and leave live sports to the pros?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/10/sports/fans-bash-netflix-over-audio-issues-during-nfl-game/

TRENDING TODAY

■ *Backlash Grows as Texas Republican Convention Flashes Hasan Piker Underwear Pic on Jumbotron: 'They Want Him so Bad'*

The Angle: *A state political convention accidentally turned into a meme by flashing a shirtless/underwear photo of left-wing streamer Hasan Piker on the big screen — and the internet immediately clocked the irony of Republicans fixating on him.*

- The image reportedly went up on a **jumbotron** at the **Texas Republican Convention**.
- The photo was of streamer **Hasan Piker**, shown in his **underwear**.
- Online reaction leaned into the irony, with commenters joking **'they want him so bad'**.

- Story is circulating widely on **r/nottheonion**, signaling viral, not-just-political-junkie reach.

The Debate Starter

- Callers: is this just a convention screwup, or proof your political opponents are more obsessed with you than your own side is?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://thenerdstash.com/backlash-grows-as-texas-republican-convention-flashes-hasan-piker-underwear-pic-on-jumbotron-they-want-him-so-bad/

Backup options:

■ *'Entourage' Creator Slams Ad Reuniting Jeremy Piven and Adrian Grenier - Variety*

The Angle: *A nostalgic reunion ad just turned into a public feud, with the show's own creator publicly trashing it - that's the kind of Hollywood pettiness that gets people talking.*

- **Doug Ellin**, creator of **Entourage**, publicly slammed a new ad reuniting stars **Jeremy Piven** and **Adrian Grenier**.
- He called it a **"cheap, shitty imitation"** of his HBO comedy.
- Piven and Grenier reunited on screen for the ad, seemingly without Ellin's blessing.

The Debate Starter

- Is it fair for a creator to trash his own former stars for cashing in on nostalgia, or is that just Hollywood being Hollywood?

Variety (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/tv/news/entourage-creator-slams-ad-jeremy-piven-adrian-grenier-1236856363/

■ *Kris Jenner’s alleged ‘stalker’ has explosive criminal history, bizarre behavior caught on video*

The Angle: *A guy with a documented history of legal trouble in Hawaii allegedly shows up fixated on Kris Jenner — it's the kind of celebrity-safety story that always gets people talking about how exposed famous people really are.*

- Suspect **Zenwilliam Bronze Robson**, **25**, was arrested on **Sept. 7**
- Robson allegedly has a history of legal issues out of **Hawaii** before this arrest
- Reports describe 'bizarre behavior' from Robson caught on video

The Debate Starter

- How much protection is actually enough when a celebrity has a known stalker with a history like this?

pagesix.com (Tier 2) | Score: 74/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/2026/09/10/celebrity-news/kris-jenners-alleged-stalker-has-explosive-criminal-history/

LIFESTYLE CHAT

■ *A butterfly that was down to just 9 known in the US in 2022 has been brought back from the brink of extinction. After researchers released more than 1,300 captive raised Poweshiek skipperlings in 2025, they are now seeing hundreds in the wild at recovery sites.*

The Angle: *This little guy was down to single digits in the wild two years ago — basically extinction-watch territory — and now scientists have hundreds of them flying around again. It's the rare good-news environmental story that isn't just 'we're doomed.'*

- The **Poweshiek skipperling** was down to just **9 known individuals** in the US in **2022**.
- Researchers released more than **1,300 captive-raised** skipperlings back into the wild in **2025**.
- They're now spotting **hundreds** of them at recovery sites in the wild.

The Feel-Good Angle

- When's the last time you heard an animal was saved from basically going extinct — and does that news ever actually reach people, or does it just get drowned out by bad news?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://msutoday.msu.edu/news/2026/08/bringing-butterflies-back-from-extinction

Backup options:

■ *Norway's capital Oslo, said it had banned smart glasses in schools, saying the move was aimed at preventing children from becoming "extras in Meta's data collection"*

The Angle: *This is the privacy backlash getting real: a major European capital is drawing a hard line on AI wearables in classrooms, and it's forcing the question every parent is quietly asking — how much of my kid's life is Big Tech quietly recording?*

- **Oslo**, the capital of **Norway**, has banned smart glasses in its schools.
- City officials say the goal is to stop kids from becoming **"extras in Meta's data collection"**.
- The move targets AI-camera-equipped glasses like **Meta's Ray-Bans**, which can record video/audio of everyone nearby without a visible signal.

The Debate Starter

- Should schools here ban smart glasses too, or is this just Europe being extra about tech again?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.thelocal.no/20260910/oslo-bans-smart-glasses-in-schools

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■ *Belly Fat, Not Age, May Be Bigger Driver of Low Testosterone: Visceral fat, or deep fat in abdomen, may be more precise determinant of testosterone suppression. Reducing visceral fat with drugs like Ozempic or Wegovy may address low testosterone more directly than testosterone replacement therapy.*

The Angle: *Every guy over 35 blames low T on getting older, but new research says belly fat — not birthdays — might be the real culprit, and that reframes a huge chunk of men's health chatter.*

- New research points to **visceral fat** (the deep abdominal fat around organs) as a more precise driver of **low testosterone** than age itself
- Popular weight-loss drugs like **Ozempic** and **Wegovy** could end up treating low T indirectly by targeting that belly fat
- Suggests **testosterone replacement therapy** may be treating a symptom, not the root cause, for some men

The Debate Starter

- So is the fix for 'low T' actually just a smaller waistline instead of a prescription?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.sciencealert.com/belly-fat-not-age-may-be-the-bigger-driver-of-low-testosterone

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CLOSER: THROWBACK THURSDAY

■ *Cult classic Donnie Darko will return to theaters in 4K for its 25th anniversary in October*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A 25th-anniversary 4K theatrical return of a genuine cult classic gives fans a specific date and reason to mobilize, a pattern that reliably outperforms generic nostalgia posts.

The Angle: *It's the ultimate dorm-room cult classic getting the royal treatment for its 25th birthday — perfect throwback bait for anyone who still argues about what that ending actually means.*

- **Donnie Darko** returns to theaters for its **25th anniversary**
- The rerelease comes in a fully remastered **4K** version

- It hits theaters starting **October** — timed right for spooky season

The Rewatch Debate

- Be honest — are you buying a ticket to relive this one, or was it strictly a college-apartment-couch movie?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: The 60-Second Explain-It Challenge** - clock it live on air -> Give each host 60 seconds to explain the Donnie Darko time-travel plot from memory — no cheating, no Googling.
- **Step 2: First Watch Flashback** - quick round, keep it moving -> Each host shares where/when they first saw it and whether it actually holds up 25 years later.

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 73/90 (40 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.thehorrorlounge.com/post/cult-classic-donnie-darko-will-return-to-theaters-in-4k-for-its-25th-anniversary-in-october

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FLEX (cap check: THE GREAT DEBATE 0/4 this month; TECH TALK 2/3 this month; Advice/Relationship Cluster 4/3 this month)

(no flex-slot candidates cleared the cap/score bar today)

ADDITIONAL CANDIDATES (no specific segment match, but scored well on source/quality - producer's call on where these fit)

■■ *The Vatican is going green, preparing a 424 hectare solar farm near Rome that is nearly 10 times the size of Vatican City and is intended to provide all of the city state's electricity. The project will also preserve agricultural use of the land beneath the panels.*

The Angle: *The Pope's turning the Vatican into a green-energy poster child with a solar farm way bigger than the Vatican itself — it's a fun, feel-good story about the world's smallest country going big on clean energy.*

- The solar farm will cover **424 hectares** near Rome
- That's nearly **10 times the size** of Vatican City itself
- The goal: power **100% of Vatican City's electricity**
- Farmland underneath the panels stays in use for **agriculture**

The Watercooler Take

- The Vatican just out-green'd basically every country on Earth by building a solar farm 10 times its own size — who saw that coming?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.ecoticias.com/en/the-vatican-is-preparing-a-solar-farm-nearly-ten-times-its-own-size-north-of-rome-but-the-field-is-still-waiting-for-its-first-panel/36626/

■ *Russia sends bones of medieval warrior prince to Ukraine front to boost morale*

The Angle: *A story so strange it landed on r/nottheonion — Russia allegedly sending the skeletal remains of a medieval warrior prince to the front lines as a morale booster is the kind of real-life-is-stranger-than-fiction moment that's built for a quick on-air reaction.*

- **Russia** reportedly sent the bones of a **medieval warrior prince** to troops on the **Ukraine front**.
- The stated purpose: boosting **troop morale** with a centuries-old relic.
- The story is making rounds via **r/nottheonion**, a subreddit dedicated to real headlines that sound fake.

The Head-Scratcher

- Nothing boosts morale on a modern battlefield quite like a 700-year-old skeleton — discuss.

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.straitstimes.com/world/europe/russia-sends-bones-of-medieval-warrior-prince-to-ukraine-front-to-boost-morale

■ *Former Obama Admin Official Says It's Time To Consider Military Strikes on Chinese Data Centers to Prevent Them From Reaching AGI*

The Angle: *Former Obama Admin Official Says It's Time To Consider Military Strikes on Chinese Data Centers to Prevent Them From Reaching AGI*

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.yahoo.com/news/politics/articles/former-obama-admin-official-says-180208350.html

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BREAKOUT WATCH (below the show's usual engagement bar - included on editorial judgment, not metrics; producer's call)

■ *A new generation of batteries could make storing clean energy cheaper and easier: sodium ion batteries use abundant materials, work in extreme temperatures without cooling systems and are already moving into mass production at major battery factories.*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Sodium-ion batteries hit directly on the hottest current cleantech narrative (China's sodium-ion EV/grid rollout), giving it real trend-alignment beyond typical feel-good energy posts.
The Angle: *A new type of battery swaps expensive lithium for salt, of all things, and it could make clean energy storage cheaper for everyone. It's already moving into real factories, not just a lab experiment.*

- **Sodium-ion batteries** use sodium instead of lithium, and sodium is way more abundant and cheaper to source.
- They can handle **extreme temperatures** without needing a separate cooling system.
- They're already **moving into mass production** at major battery factories, not just prototypes.

The Wallet Angle

- If a battery made from basically salt could make your next phone, car, or power wall cheaper, does the brand name even matter to you anymore?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.solarpowerworldonline.com/2026/08/sodium-ion-batteries-are-ready-for-world-domination/

■ *California city canceled Flock, removed its cameras, then found the company had put some of them back*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A city banning Flock cameras only to have the company quietly reinstall them taps directly into the surging national backlash against ALPR surveillance overreach, giving it a sharp 'corporate defiance' hook.
The Angle: *A California city voted to dump its license-plate camera contract and yank the cameras down, only to discover the company quietly put some of them back up — a real-life "we said no" moment that's got surveillance-skeptics and privacy folks fired up.*

- A **California city** canceled its contract with license-plate reading company **Flock** and had the cameras removed.
- Some of those same cameras reportedly went back up anyway, seemingly without the city's sign-off.
- Story is blowing up on **r/nottheonion** for how brazenly it plays out.

The Debate Starter

- If a company you fired put its equipment right back up on your street, would you even notice?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 53/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality - 25 penalty (used within the last 30 days)) -> STRONG

URL: https://www.techspot.com/news/113769-california-city-canceled-flock-removed-cameras-found-company.html

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■ *NASA found possible sign of life on Mars, but sample remains stuck there*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): 'Possible sign of life on Mars' is about as big a science headline as exists, and its current 291 likes look low relative to the scale of the claim,

suggesting it just hasn't been seen by the right audience yet.
The Angle: *This is peak 2026 irony: humanity might have finally found a sign we're not alone in the universe, and the evidence is just sitting on Mars because we don't have a way to grab it and fly it back yet.*

- **NASA** says it found a **possible sign of life** on **Mars**
- The sample is reportedly **stuck there** with no ride home
- Story is making rounds on **r/nottheonion** for how absurd the timing/logistics are

The Debate Starter

- If NASA can find hints of alien life but can't retrieve the evidence, are we even a serious space-faring species yet?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.newsweek.com/nasa-found-possible-sign-life-mars-sample-stuck-12416439

■ *Xbox Swoops In To Save Kojima's Stealth Action Game Physint After PlayStation Tried To Cancel It*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A platform holder trying to kill a Kojima game only for a rival console maker to publicly rescue it is rare, dramatic industry news with a marquee name attached.
The Angle: *A huge gaming-world name, Hideo Kojima, and a console war plot twist — his stealth game reportedly got cancelled by PlayStation and swooped up by Xbox, which is exactly the kind of corporate drama gamers eat up.*

- **Hideo Kojima's** stealth action game **Physint** reportedly faced cancellation at **PlayStation**
- **Xbox** reportedly stepped in to save the project

The Debate Starter

- Sony or Microsoft — who actually treats big-name game creators better?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://kotaku.com/xbox-swoops-in-to-save-kojimas-stealth-action-game-physint-after-playstation-tried-to-cancel-it-2000732992

■ *Hideo Kojima’s Physint has jumped from PlayStation to Xbox, after Kojima says Sony tried to cancel it*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Same Kojima/Physint platform-switch drama appearing as a second independently-performing post signals early cross-source momentum rather than a one-off spike.
The Angle: *Hideo Kojima is one of the most famous names in gaming, and his claim that Sony tried to cancel Physint before it jumped ship to Xbox is exactly the kind of console-war drama that gets gamers and non-gamers alike talking about loyalty, big-budget bets gone wrong, and Xbox's aggressive exclusive-poaching push.*

- **Hideo Kojima**, the legendary creator behind **Metal Gear Solid** and **Death Stranding**, is behind the game **Physint**.
- Kojima says **Sony** tried to cancel the project.
- **Physint** has now moved from **PlayStation** to **Xbox**.

The Console Wars Debate

- Would you switch platforms just to follow a favorite creator's next game?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.videogameschronicle.com/news/hideo-kojimas-physint-has-jumped-from-playstation-to-xbox-after-kojima-says-sony-tried-to-cancel-it/

FRANCHISE BANK

WHAT THE FRIDAY: 4 banked (+15 each when found)

- "Abdul El-Sayed asks Fox News' Jesse Watters 'Are you circumcised?' in bizarre moment as he defends sex change surgery for minors https://t.c" (X/Twitter @NYPost, banked 2026-08-24)
- "The bizarre thing Nicole Kidman does to Sandra Bullock when she sees her" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-08-29)
- "Tiny mouse brawl breaks out on London subway platform" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-08)
- "Dramatic video shows naked man being pulled from East River by NYC cops" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-09)

THROWBACK THURSDAY: 12 banked (+15 each when found)

- "Pokémon 30th Anniversary TCG Set Might Feature Rarest Mew Ever - Kotaku" (Kotaku (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-08-21)
- "Sonic the Hedgehog to Headline Fortnite's 'Override' Season (Gaming News Roundup)" (variety.com, banked 2026-08-22)
- "Ranch Ehrlo Society celebrates milestone anniversary with powwow" (CTV News (via Google News), banked 2026-08-28)
- "Beyoncé Details Expansive, 27-Track 20th Anniversary 'B'Day' Deluxe Edition Featuring B-Sides, Spanish-Language Versions" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-08-28)
- "'A modern Dickie Dee bike': Sask. boy serves up sweet treats with a side of nostalgia https://t.co/tiDR4cbOP1" (X/Twitter @CTVNews, banked 2026-08-30)
- "9/11 cancers skyrocket nearly 1,700% as toxic toll on survivors surpasses first responders ahead of 25th anniversary https://t.co/HWOFfTeKZb" (X/Twitter @NYPost, banked 2026-08-31)
- "Zendaya Rings in 30 with an Adorable Throwback Photo: 'So Much to Be Grateful for' - people.com" (People (via Google News), banked 2026-09-01)
- "Here's Why Fifth Harmony Fans Think the Girl Group Is Making a Comeback Ahead of Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-06)
- "Rachael Leigh Cook surprises fans at 'Josie and the Pussycats' 25th anniversary screening" (pagesix.com, banked 2026-09-07)
- "Stevie Wonder Announces 'Songs in the Key of Life' 50th Anniversary Tour https://t.co/trmKJsgwqb" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-08)
- "Michael Goodwin: Mamdani's toxic Ground Zero blame game just latches on to still-open 9/11 wounds to boost himself" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-08)
- "John Oliver to Host Comic Relief Live's 40th Anniversary Show" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-09-09)

SOURCES SKIPPED THIS RUN:

- @CBCNews (fetch failed)
- @Gizmodo (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- Morning Brew (OpenCLI browser-scrape returned nothing - check Chrome/bridge)
- 2 story(ies) removed after slotting (content-safety and/or not-significant-enough for THE LIST/TRENDING TODAY; automatically backfilled where possible; see run log)

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